

1. Definition of Comics and Time:

Eisner defines comics as Sequential Art, where the artist creates the illusion of time through panel layout, treating time as a psychological effect. McCloud formalizes this as juxtaposed pictorial and other images in deliberate sequence, establishing the structural rule that space equals time, where narrative time is a linear path across the physical page. Sousanis challenges this linearity, viewing comics as a spatial interplay of the sequential and the simultaneous, akin to a network that allows the past, present, and future to coexist, activating both linear (left) and holistic (right) brain hemispheres.

2. PERSPECTIVE

EISNER

Eisner classified perspective into the following subcategories, eye-level view, overhead view, ground-level view and worm's eye view.

MCLOUD

McCloud believes that the gutter is the most important aspect of comics (in the "blood in the gutter").

SOUSANIS

Comics as a tool to break free from flat linear thinking and regain multidimensional sight. He illustrates humans as being trapped in a flatland grid, moving like clockwork. To unflatten via stereoscopic vision.

3. Terms: Symbol, Icon, and Flatness:

Eisner focuses on "common imagery" or "visual shorthand"—gestures and poses based on shared experience as a "common symbol" system for efficient storytelling. McCloud establishes the formal term "Icon" to differentiate between realistic art and simplified images that represent universal concepts (e.g., a simple face icon). Sousanis introduces the critical terminology of "Flatness" and "Unflattening." He uses "Flatness" to critique the limitations of traditional, linear, text-based thinking that forces complex ideas into one-dimensional thought. His solution, "Unflattening," is the act of using the hybrid nature of comics to restore multidimensional understanding.

Ideas:

Part 1: Definition of Comics & Time

Theme: Narrative Flow

1. **Eisner (Rhythm):** The artist controls the "beat" of time; panels act as musical notes to dictate pace (slow/fast).
2. **McCloud (Linearity):** Space is time; narrative progresses linearly from panel to panel.
3. **Sousanis (Network):** Comics combine sequential reading with simultaneous viewing of the whole (Constellation).

Part 2: Perspective

Theme: Angle of Vision

1. **Eisner (Emotion):** Perspective is used to manipulate the reader's emotion (e.g., Bird's Eye View for fear/dominance).
2. **McCloud (Identification):** Simple characters ("the Mask") facilitate reader identification with the story.
3. **Sousanis (Depth):** Combining the viewpoints of text and image creates depth/truth (Stereoscope/Parallax).

Part 3: Terms & Concepts

Theme: Building Blocks

1. **Eisner (Vocabulary):** Eisner explains that comics rely on **repeated, recognizable images** that function as shared vocabulary. He shows how recurring postures and simplified figures become readable symbols (e.g., the kneeling "worship" pose evolving across styles). He writes that letters are symbols derived from images and that repeated images become a "literary form" with its own grammar.
2. **McCloud (Icon):** McCloud defines an **icon** as any image that represents a person, place, thing, or idea. Unlike Eisner, he emphasizes *degrees of abstraction*. An **icon** ranges from realistic depiction → simplified cartoon → pure symbol.

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4. **Sousanis (Unflattening):** Escaping one-dimensional/linear thinking (Jailbreak).

Will Eisner — Perspective as Meaning

Concept: *A single street confrontation shown through changing perspectives to control emotion and power.*

Comic example idea:

A character is walking alone at night.

- **Panel 1 (Eye-level view):**
The reader sees the street from the character's height. Shops are closed, streetlights glow dimly.

- **Panel 2 (Overhead view):**

The same street is shown from above. The character looks small, surrounded by dark alleys.

- **Panel 3 (Ground-level view):**

The camera drops low near the pavement. Two unfamiliar shoes enter the frame in front of the character.

- **Panel 4 (Worm's-eye view):**

The attacker looms overhead, filling the frame. From below, the figure appears dominant and threatening, emphasizing power imbalance and fear.

Scott McCloud – The Gutter as Storytelling (“Blood in the Gutter”)

Concept: *Violence and meaning occur between panels, not inside them.*

Comic example idea:

A heated argument escalates.

- **Panel 1:**

Two characters argue. One raises a clenched fist. No action yet.

- **Gutter (blank space):**

Nothing is shown.

- **Panel 2:**

One character is on the ground, glasses shattered, blood dripping from their mouth. The other character stands frozen in shock.

The punch is **never shown**.

What happens:

The reader's mind fills in the missing action - imagining the punch, the sound, the force. Each reader constructs a slightly different version.

Nick Sousanis - Unflattening & Multidimensional Thought

Concept: *Breaking free from rigid, linear perception using comics' spatial freedom.*

Comic example idea:

A person lives in a grid-like world.

- **Early panels:**

The page is divided into identical square panels.

The character moves mechanically - wake up, walk, work, sleep - always in straight lines. Thought bubbles repeat the same phrases. Everything is flat, repetitive, clockwork-like.

- **Middle spread:**

The character looks up and notices overlapping images, memories, emotions, dreams, bleeding outside the grid panels. The panels start to tilt and break.

- **Final spread:**

The grid disappears completely. Panels float, overlap, and layer perspectives. The character is shown multiple times at once, thinking, remembering, imagining, seeing depth like **stereoscopic vision**.

